

MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

KPIS

FEW GOALS, CLEAR ONES

Why a clear, difficult goal works better than "do your best", what happens when there are too many, and when goals do harm.



49%

of US employees strongly agree that they know what is expected of them at work. The item has fallen nine points since 2020.

GALLUP, 2026

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A team with many goals in fact has few. This issue is about goals that work: specific, difficult and few, and about the harm they do when they are set badly.

In 2002 Edwin Locke and Gary Latham summed up three and a half decades of research on goals. George Doran gave managers SMART in 1981. In 2009 four researchers warned about the side effects of goals. And Gallup finds that only about half of US employees clearly know what is expected of them.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure

Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading

Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice

The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

"Do your best" is not a goal

In 2002 Edwin Locke and Gary Latham summed up 35 years of research. The central finding: specific, difficult goals lead to better results than the call to "do your best".

The reason: "do your best" has no reference point, so everyone measures it for themselves. Performance rose with the difficulty of the goal until it reached the limits of ability or commitment fell. Three things strengthen or weaken the effect: commitment to the goal, feedback on progress and the complexity of the task. On new, complex tasks a learning goal can work better than a number.

"Do your best"

No reference point

Everyone measures it alone

Nobody knows when it is enough



1981

Doran: SMART, five criteria for an objective.



2002

Locke and Latham: 35 years of research on goals.

Clear and difficult

A number and a date

The same for everyone

Feedback shows where you stand



2009

"Goals Gone Wild": goals have side effects.



2012

4DX: one or two wildly important goals per team.

OUR READING

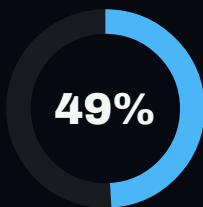
A vague goal does not lower the pressure. It moves it to each person, who decides alone what "enough" means.

Sources: Edwin A. Locke & Gary P. Latham, American Psychologist, 2002; George T. Doran, Management Review, 1981; Lisa D. Ordóñez, Maurice E. Schweitzer, Adam D. Galinsky & Max H. Bazerman, 2009; Chris McChesney, Sean Covey & Jim Huling, 2012 (via FranklinCovey, Discipline 1)

THE NUMBERS

Only half know what is expected

Gallup asks employees whether they know what is expected of them at work. In the US this item has fallen more than any other since 2020.



of US employees strongly agree that they know what is expected of them (Gallup, 2026).

-9 points

since 2020, the largest drop among Gallup's twelve items in the US

0.42-0.80

effect size of specific, difficult goals over "do your best" in earlier reviews (Locke & Latham)

1-2

wildly important goals per team, as 4DX advises

Gallup places this item at the base of engagement: among its twelve elements, knowing what is expected is one of the two basic needs on which the others rest.

OUR READING

The question "do you know what is expected of you?" costs a minute. Not having the answer costs a shift.

Sources: Gallup, Indicator: Employee Engagement, 2026; Jim Harter, Gallup, 2026; Gallup, Gallup's Employee Engagement Survey: Ask the Right Questions With the Q12 Survey, 2026; Edwin A. Locke & Gary P. Latham, American Psychologist, 2002; Chris McChesney, Sean Covey & Jim Huling, 2012 (via FranklinCovey, Discipline 1)

THE MODEL

SMART, and what it lacks

George Doran wrote SMART in 1981, in a two-page article. In the original, A stood for "assignable" and R for "realistic"; later versions changed them.

01 Specific One area, named clearly.	02 Measurable A number or a clear sign of progress.	03 Assignable Who owns it.	04 Realistic Achievable with the resources at hand.	05 Time-related When the result is due.
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HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, ONE GOAL BEFORE AND AFTER

Before Improve the service.

After Cut delay complaints from 40 to 25 a week by 30 November; owned by the evening shift lead.

The numbers are invented.

SMART asks for

A clear, measurable goal

An owner, a deadline, a realistic target

The research adds

Difficulty: hard goals do more

Commitment, and feedback on progress

OUR READING

SMART makes a goal clear. It does not tell you whether it is the right goal, or how many goals a team can carry.

Sources: George T. Doran, Management Review, 1981; Edwin A. Locke & Gary P. Latham, American Psychologist, 2002

Doran himself wrote that not every objective has to be measured in numbers.

THE RISK

When goals do harm

In 2009 four researchers wrote that goals are like a prescription drug: they work, but they have side effects and need careful dosing.

01 Narrow focus

What is not measured is neglected, even when it matters.

02 Unethical behaviour

When the number is all that counts, some reach it by any means.

03 Excess risk

Goals that are too hard push people towards risks nobody would otherwise accept.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A CALL CENTRE

The team is measured only on call length. Agents close calls quickly, and customers call again. The number improves; the problem does not.

Locke and Latham contested the critique the same year. The authors of *The 4 Disciplines of Execution* (2012) add a practical limit: one or two wildly important goals per team, because the more goals at once, the fewer are achieved well.

OUR READING

The second question after "what is the goal?" is "what are we neglecting to reach it?"

Sources: Lisa D. Ordóñez, Maurice E. Schweitzer, Adam D. Galinsky & Max H. Bazerman, 2009; Edwin A. Locke & Gary P. Latham, *Academy of Management Perspectives*, 2009; Chris McChesney, Sean Covey & Jim Huling, 2012 (via FranklinCovey, Discipline 1)

HOW IT IS MEASURED

How many goals does your team have?

Goals arrive from many directions: the company, the boss, the customer, the audit. Counting them is the first step to making them few and clear.

1

Count

Write down every goal, target or threshold the team is asked to hit, from every source.

2

Ask the team

Ask the team to name the goals without notes. Mark which ones they mention.

3

Choose

One or two for the quarter, with the reason why.

4

Say it openly

What moves to second place, and who knows it.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A WAREHOUSE TEAM

The team has nine targets from three sources. Without notes, people name three. The lead picks two for the quarter and writes them on the board; the others are kept but not discussed every day. The numbers are invented.

OUR READING

A team with nine goals has, in practice, one: the one the boss asked about last.

The steps and the example are the editors'.

More in the essay

Ten minutes before the shift: what the team needs to know before the work starts

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The goal card

One goal, one page. Fill it in with the team and put it where every shift sees it.

01 The goal, in one sentence from X to Y, by when

02 Why it matters for the customer or the team

03 What we do every week the signal that moves the goal

04 Who owns it one role, not a group

05 What we set aside so that this goal can happen

06 Review date, and where we are

A practice proposed by the editors, after Locke and Latham and Doran. Do not write confidential figures on the card.

Open the tool: [KPI Diagnostic](#)

stivencatalyst.com/tools/kpi-diagnostic/

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

Building a Practically Useful Theory of Goal Setting and Task Motivation

Edwin A. Locke & Gary P. Latham, American Psychologist, 2002

<https://doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.57.9.705>

There's a S.M.A.R.T. way to write management's goals and objectives

George T. Doran, Management Review, 1981

Goals Gone Wild: The Systematic Side Effects of Overprescribing Goal Setting

Lisa D. Ordóñez, Maurice E. Schweitzer, Adam D. Galinsky & Max H. Bazerman, 2009

https://repository.upenn.edu/mgmt_papers/325

Has Goal Setting Gone Wild, or Have Its Attackers Abandoned Good Scholarship?

Edwin A. Locke & Gary P. Latham, Academy of Management Perspectives, 2009

The 4 Disciplines of Execution

Chris McChesney, Sean Covey & Jim Huling, 2012 · via FranklinCovey, Discipline 1

<https://www.franklincovey.com/courses/the-4-discipline/s/discipline-1-wildly-important/>

Indicator: Employee Engagement

Gallup, 2026

<https://www.gallup.com/394373/indicator-employee-engagement.aspx>

Employee Engagement Declines From 2020 Peak

Jim Harter, Gallup, 2026

<https://www.gallup.com/workplace/701486/employee-engagement-declines-2020-peak.aspx>

Gallup's Employee Engagement Survey: Ask the Right Questions With the Q12 Survey

Gallup, 2026

<https://q12.gallup.com/>

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

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Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/management-review.html